

educational institutes. A year later, he apologised for the anti-Sikh riots of 1984.

2007 Nuclear Obsession

From here on, the Manmohan Singh regime became a one-issue government in the sole pursuit of the nuclear deal. The prime minister gave the famous "So Be It" ultimatum to the Left. After almost a year of instability, the Left pulled out in July 2008.

2008 Political Coup

The bureaucratic prime minister pulled out his first political rabbit and won the trust vote in Parliament by roping in the Samajwadi Party. He goes into the elections trading political fire with L.K. Advani, refuting the charge that he was India's weakest prime minister.



KALYAN CHAKRAVORTY

2009 United Front

Manmohan's rivals projected Rahul as the next prime minister. But the dynasty came out in his support. Even when he went for heart surgery, Sonia refused to name a number two to avoid any challenge to his leadership. Manmohan as prime minister is crucial to her succession plan.



YASBANT NEGI

guidance and consistent support, our government will do better," he said at the release of the party manifesto. This kind of modesty doesn't help in politics, particularly when it comes from a prime minister who is yet to acquire the tact and savvy of a street smart politician. And it is as if he is falling into the trap set by his challenger, the BJP's prime ministerial candidate, who continues to call him "the weakest prime minister".

Sonia has clearly learnt her lesson well. This is the second time when there has been a non-Gandhi Congress prime minister in Race Course Road with her at 10 Janpath. During Rao's tenure, the grieving widow watched in anguish the rise of an usurper from outside the dynasty. Ironically, Manmohan was then one of Rao's key ministers. Despite being a political novice, the then finance minister was smart enough to keep an independent channel of communication with 10 Janpath. And Rao was not in awe of Sonia anyway. She used to publicly express her anguish over the delay in Rajiv Gandhi's assassination trial. Today, diktats have replaced anguish as the mode of communication with the PMO.

The dutiful chief executive and the dictating empress mark the duality of power. Delivering his first Independence Day speech from Red Fort, Manmohan had said, "I have no promises to make, only promises to keep." Making promises is the job of a politician. It is Sonia who announces a petrol price cut. It is Manmohan's job to ensure that this happens. He knows that his role, despite its prime ministerial trappings, is essentially bureaucratic in nature. For five years, he has run a government according to the whims of his mentor. It is a relationship that works and he is used to taking orders. He is the reformer of the marketplace, and someone who is worthy of being projected as the brand ambassador of 21st Century India. He is the administrator who is willing to be politically directed. He is the man of the minutiae and she is the ultimate arbiter who has to play out the populist script. He is the foreign expert, striking nuclear deals while she manages the domestic front, striking cross-party alliances. She decides, he implements.

Yet Sonia is always careful not to be disrespectful of the prime minister. When she realised that he had staked his personal prestige on the nuclear deal, she got the party to

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doesn't mean the achievements of Manmohan. It is the achievement of the Family, for the Family has the complete copyright over the product called Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. When the party, which is completely subordinated to the First Parivar of Indian politics, talks about its vision for the future, the spotlight inevitably shifts to Rahul. "Being nominated prime minister is a great honour and a privilege. I am confident that with Mrs Gandhi's

back him. It was one issue on which he wanted to build the legacy of his Government. And it was an issue that brought out his first political instincts. For a while, he was the conviction politician. And Sonia let him play the role. It is she who always calls on him at Race Course Road; he is never summoned to 10 Janpath. He is always referred to as Manmohan Singhji. She will always stand up to greet him and will never leave a government function before him.